first-choice Test wicketkeeper. He claimed a remarkable 555 Test dismissals, including 532 catches and 23 stumpings, more than any other keeper in the history of the game – 139 ahead of Adam Gilchrist, of Australia, who is second on the all-time list. As a batsman who generally came in at No. 7 or No. 8, he scored 5 515 Test runs, most of them made under pressure as, seemingly again and again, he rose to the challenge of digging his team out of trouble.

The quality of his performances over such a long period was astonishing and, on a personal level, I recall so many moments when he went out of his way to look after me.

When I was a nervous 20-year-old at my very first Proteas training camp in Pretoria, he invited me to join him and a few others for a drink at DropZone in Hatfield, and he took me aside and told me I should relax because he was sure I would do well. Better than anyone, he understood how an apprehensive youngster can be boosted when a senior player takes just a moment to say the right things at the right time.

That week and through all the weeks that followed, he was always beside me, the first to praise me when things went well and the first to console me when things went wrong. He taught me the importance of working hard – come on, he would say, let's go to the gym and train. And he taught me the importance of taking time to unwind in what was always a demanding schedule – come on, he would say, let's go play golf or let's go for a run or let's go swim or let's take the guys out for a drink.

Professional sport is often portrayed as a ruthless, selfish, competitive environment where veterans warn younger players to look after themselves because nobody else will look after them. That's just how it is, they would say, because there's always somebody wanting to take your place and threaten your livelihood.

Through his words and actions, Mark Boucher proved that the opposite can be true. He has always been incredibly giving, offering his time, encouragement and advice. 'Hey, Bunk,' he would say to me at the end